

Weather & Seasons

Weather is the #1 small talk topic in Sweden — and for good reason. The country transforms dramatically between seasons. Master weather talk and you'll always have something to say to any Swede, anywhere, anytime.

Talking About the Weather

Swedes are obsessed with weather. It's the one safe small talk topic that never fails. A sunny day in Sweden is basically a national holiday — people flood parks, cafés move outside, and strangers actually smile at each other. Use these phrases and you'll fit right in.

Fint väder idag!

/fint VEH-der ee-DAHG/

Nice weather today! — THE Swedish conversation opener. Use daily.

Vilken fin dag!

/VIL-ken feen dahg/

What a beautiful day! — Extra enthusiasm for sunny days.

Det regnar

/deh REG-nar/

It's raining — You'll say this a lot, especially in Gothenburg.

Det snöar

/deh SNUH-ar/

It's snowing.

Det är kallt

/deh air kahlt/

It's cold.

Det är jättekallt!

/deh air YEH-teh-kahlt/

It's really cold! — When regular 'kallt' doesn't cover it.

Det är varmt

/deh air varmt/

It's warm — Anything above 20°C and Swedes consider it warm.

Det blåser

/deh BLOH-ser/

It's windy.

Vilken gråväder!

/VIL-ken GROH-veh-der/

What gray weather! — November in Sweden, basically.

Solen skiner!

/SOH-len SHEE-ner/

The sun is shining! — Say this with the excitement it deserves.

CULTURE TIP

When the sun comes out in Sweden — especially after a long dark winter — the entire country transforms. People sit outside at the first sign of sunshine, even if it's only 10°C. Parks fill up. Everyone's mood lifts. If you see Swedes sunbathing in what you consider cold weather, that's normal. They've earned it.

Weather Vocabulary

More weather words for when you need to be specific — or understand the forecast.

Sol / Moln / Dimma

/sohl / moln / DIM-ah/

Sun / Clouds / Fog.

Regn / Snö / Hagel

/regn / snuh / HAH-gehl/

Rain / Snow / Hail.

Åska / Blixt

/OHS-kah / blikst/

Thunder / Lightning.

Is / Halka

/ees / HAL-kah/

Ice / Slippery conditions — Very important in winter!

Plusgrader / Minusgrader

/PLOOS-grah-der / MEE-noos-grah-der/

Above zero / Below zero — Sweden uses Celsius.

Hur många grader är det?

/hoor MONG-ah GRAH-der air deh/

How many degrees is it? — Asking about temperature.

Väderprognosen

/VEH-der-prog-NOH-sen/

The weather forecast — Check yr.no or SMHI.se for Swedish forecasts.

Det ska bli bättre imorgon

/deh skah blee BEH-treh ee-MOR-on/

It's supposed to get better tomorrow — Swedish optimism in one phrase.

CULTURE TIP

Sweden uses Celsius, not Fahrenheit. Quick reference: 0°C = freezing, 10°C = cool jacket weather, 15°C = Swedes start wearing shorts, 20°C = officially warm, 25°C = hot (seriously), 30°C = national emergency (Swedes melt). Winter can go to -20°C or lower in the north.

The Four Seasons of Sweden

Each Swedish season is dramatically different. The country literally transforms. Understanding the seasons helps you plan, pack, and connect with Swedes about the one thing they all experience together.

Vår (March – May)

/vohr/

Spring — The snow melts, days get longer, and Swedes come back to life. First outdoor fika of the year.

Sommar (June – August)

/SOM-ar/

Summer — Long days, midnight sun in the north, Midsommar, swimming, and outdoor living. Sweden's best season.

Höst (September – November)

/huhst/

Autumn — Beautiful colors, mushroom picking, cozy vibes. Gets dark fast.

Vinter (December – February)

/VIN-ter/

Winter — Short days, snow, freezing temps. But also Christmas, ice skating, and northern lights.

Seasonal Events & Traditions

Sweden's calendar is built around seasonal celebrations. Knowing these helps you understand why the entire country shuts down at certain times.

Midsommar

/MID-som-ar/

Midsummer (late June) — The biggest summer celebration. Dancing around a maypole, herring, strawberries, and a lot of snaps. Many Swedes consider this more important than Christmas.

Jul

/yoöl/

Christmas (December) — Celebrated on December 24th (Julafton), not the 25th. Includes julbord (Christmas buffet), glögg (mulled wine), and Kalle Anka (Donald Duck on TV at 3 PM).

Lucia (13 December)

/loo-SEE-ah/

Saint Lucia Day — A stunning candlelit procession with white robes and singing. One of the most beautiful Swedish traditions.

Påsk

/posk/

Easter — Kids dress up as Easter witches (påskkäringar) and go door to door for candy.

Valborg / Valborgsmässoafton

/VAL-bor / VAL-borgs-MES-oh-AF-ton/

Walpurgis Night (April 30) — Huge bonfires to welcome spring. Big student celebrations.

Krätskiva

/KREFT-shee-vah/

Crayfish party (August) — Eating crayfish with bibs, silly hats, singing, and a LOT of snaps.

Kanelbullens dag

/kah-NEHL-BUH-lens dahg/

Cinnamon Bun Day (October 4th) — Yes, an entire national day for cinnamon buns.

CULTURE TIP

If you're in Sweden during Midsommar, you MUST experience it. The whole country gathers in the countryside for dancing, singing drinking songs, and eating pickled herring with new potatoes and sour cream. Cities empty out — Stockholm feels like a ghost town. Get invited to a private Midsommar celebration if you can — it's unforgettable.

Dressing for Swedish Weather

There's a famous Swedish saying: 'Det finns inget dåligt väder, bara dåliga kläder' — There's no bad weather, only bad clothes. Swedes mean this literally. Here's the vocabulary for dressing right.

Jacka / Vinterjacka / Regnjacka

/YAH-kah / VIN-ter-yah-kah / REGN-yah-kah/

Jacket / Winter jacket / Rain jacket.

Mössa

/MUH-sah/

Beanie / Winter hat — Essential November through March.

Vantar / Handskar

/VAN-tar / HAND-skar/

Mittens / Gloves — Vantar (mittens) are warmer. Swedes know this.

Halsduk

/HALS-dook/

Scarf.

Stövlar / Vinterstövlar

/STUHV-lar / VIN-ter-STUHV-lar/

Boots / Winter boots — Get ones with good grip for icy sidewalks.

Regnkläder

/REGN-kleh-der/

Rain clothes — Jacket + pants. Swedes own a full set.

Lager på lager

/LAH-ger poh LAH-ger/

Layer upon layer — The Swedish layering strategy. The secret to surviving any weather.

Underställ / Långkalsonger

/OON-der-stel / LONG-kal-SONG-er/

Base layer / Long johns — Your best friend in winter. Wear these under everything.

Det är halt ute!

/deh air hahlt 00-teh/

It's slippery outside! — Watch your step on icy sidewalks.

Broddar

/BROD-ar/

Ice grips / Crampons — Attach to your shoes for walking on ice. Swedes swear by them.

CULTURE TIP

The Swedish layering system: Base layer (underställ) close to skin to wick moisture. Middle layer (fleece or wool) for warmth. Outer layer (jacket) for wind and rain protection. This system works in any temperature. In -15°C, add more middle layers. In 5°C, skip the base layer. It sounds simple but it's genuinely the best approach and every Swede learns it from childhood.

The Darkness & The Light

Nothing prepares you for how dramatic the light changes in Sweden. Summer has almost endless daylight. Winter has almost none. Understanding this helps you prepare mentally — and gives you great conversation material.

Midnattssol

/MID-nahts-sohl/

Midnight sun — In northern Sweden, the sun doesn't set for weeks in summer. Surreal and beautiful.

Mörker / Mörkertid

/MUR-ker / MUR-ker-teed/

Darkness / Dark season — In the north, the sun doesn't rise for weeks in winter.

Norrsken

/NOR-shehn/

Northern lights (Aurora Borealis) — Visible in northern Sweden from September to March. Bucket list stuff.

Det blir mörkt tidigt nu

/deh bleer murkt TEE-digt noo/

It gets dark early now — The annual autumn complaint.

Jag saknar solen

/yah SAK-nar SOH-len/

I miss the sun — You'll feel this in January. So does every Swede.

D-vitamin

/deh-vee-tah-MEEN/

Vitamin D — Many Swedes take supplements in winter. Smart move if you're staying long.

CULTURE TIP

Stockholm daylight hours vary wildly: June has 18+ hours of light (basically never gets dark). December has only about 6 hours of weak daylight. In Kiruna (far north), the sun doesn't rise at all for several weeks in December. Swedes cope with candles (lots of candles), cozy indoor time (mys), and vitamin D supplements. If you're visiting in winter, embrace the darkness — it makes the candlelit cafés and warm homes feel even more magical.

Listen to This Chapter

Scan the QR code to hear every phrase pronounced naturally. No robot voices — just real Swedish.

Next up: Chapter 10 — Nightlife & Going Out

Bars, clubs, Systembolaget, and the truth about Swedish nightlife.